

Psalms 134

A Blessing at the Close of Worship

Behold, bless ye the Lord, all ye servants of the Lord, which by night stand in the house of the Lord

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

1 Behold, bless ye the LORD, all ye servants of the LORD, which by night stand in the house of the LORD.

2 Lift up your hands in the sanctuary, and bless the LORD.

3 The LORD that made heaven and earth bless thee out of Zion.

2 · CONTEXT

The last and shortest of the Songs of Ascents, Psalm 134 functions as a closing liturgical exchange: pilgrims call the night-watch temple servants—likely priests and Levites keeping vigil after the crowds have gone—to bless the Lord, and receive in turn a blessing pronounced back on them from Zion. Henry notes the fittingness of ending this pilgrim collection not with a request but with mutual benediction, since worship's proper end is blessing given and received rather than a need still outstanding.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

The call goes out to all the Lord's servants who stand by night in His house: bless the Lord, lift up your hands in the sanctuary, and bless the Lord. Nighttime devotion—easy to skip once the visible crowds are gone—is specifically honored here as worthy of the same call to bless God as any daytime gathering.

Verse 3

The blessing is returned: may the Lord, who made heaven and earth, bless you out of Zion. The pilgrim collection closes not on a plea but on a benediction, worship completing itself in mutual blessing rather than unmet need.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Genuine worship is not only about bringing requests to God but about the mutual exchange of blessing—God's people blessing Him, and He, in turn, blessing them from His own dwelling place. The psalm's attention to hidden, nighttime devotion suggests that faithfulness unseen by the crowd matters as much as any public act of praise.

Application for life today.

Consider your own private, unseen devotion—prayer or worship no one else observes—and let this psalm affirm that such faithfulness is fully worthy of blessing God, just as public worship is. Practice ending seasons of prayer, as this psalm ends its whole collection, with deliberate blessing rather than only requests. Receive verse 3 personally: let yourself actually rest in the truth that the Maker of heaven and earth intends to bless you, not merely to answer your list of needs.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What unseen, 'nighttime' faithfulness in your own life deserves to be recognized as genuine worship, even though no one else observes it?

2. How might deliberately ending your times of prayer with blessing, rather than only requests, change your posture toward God?

3. What would it look like to actually receive verse 3's blessing personally, trusting that the Maker of heaven and earth intends good toward you specifically?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).